

something or some place. □ *Would you please call Jeff into the house?* □ *Please call in Jeff.*

call someone or something out[†] to request the services of someone or a group. (See also **call someone up**; **call someone out**.) □ *Things got bad enough that the governor called the militia out.* □ *The governor called out the militia.*

call someone or something up[†] to call someone, a group, or a company on the telephone. □ *I will call them up and see what they have to say.* □ *Please call up the supplier.*

call someone out[†] to challenge someone to a fight. □ *Wilbur wanted to call him out, but thought better of it.* □ *Why did you call out that guy? He used to be a prizefighter!*

call someone over (to some place) to request that someone come to where one is. □ *I will call her over to us, and you can ask her what you want to know.* □ *Call over the waitress so we can order.* □ *I called Ted over.*

call someone's attention to something and **call something to someone's attention** to bring something to someone's notice; to make someone recognize some fact. □ *May I call your attention to the sign on the door?* □ *He called to our attention the notice on the wall.*

call someone's bluff to demand that someone prove a claim or is not being deceptive. □ *All right, I'll call your bluff. Show me you can do it!* □ *Tom said, "You've made me really angry, and I'll punch you if you come any closer!" "Go ahead," said Bill, calling his bluff.*

call someone to account to ask one to explain and justify one's behavior, policy, performance, etc. □ *The sergeant called the police officer to account.* □ *I called my workers to account for the accident.*

call someone to attention to demand that someone assume the formal military stance of attention. □ *The officer called the platoon to attention.* □ *The sergeant called us to attention.*

call someone together to request that people come together for a meeting. □ *Please call everyone together and we'll discuss this.* □ *I called all the players together.*

call someone up[†] to request that someone or a group report for active military service. (See also **call someone or something out**.) □ *The government called the reserve units up for active service.* □ *They called up another battalion.*

call something (back) in and **call something in[†]** to formally request (usually by mail) that something be returned. □ *The car company called many cars back in for repairs.* □ *They called in a lot of cars.*

call something down[†] (on someone) *Fig.* to invoke some sort of divine punishment onto someone. □ *The preacher sounded as though he was calling down the wrath of God on us.* □ *Moses called down a plague on the Pharaoh.*

call something down[†] (to someone) to shout something to a person on a lower level. □ *The worker called a warning down to the people below.* □ *She called down a warning to them.*

call something forth[†] [for an event] to draw a particular quality or induce a particular behavior. □ *The battle called extraordinary courage forth from the soldiers.* □ *It called forth great courage.*

call something in[†] Go to **call something (back) in**.

call something off[†] to cancel an event. □ *It's too late to call the party off. The first guests have already arrived.* □ *Because of rain, they called off the baseball game.*

call something out[†] 1. to draw on something, such as a particular quality or talent. □ *It's times like these that call the best out in us.* □ *These times call out our best effort.* **2.** to shout out something. □ *Who called the warning out?* □ *You should call out a warning to those behind you on the trail.*

call something square to pronounce a debt or obligation to have been paid, balanced, or ended. □ *Thanks for the hundred bucks. I think we can call it square now.*

call something to mind and **bring something to mind** to bring something into someone's mind; to cause something to be remembered. □ *Your comment calls something unpleasant to mind.* □ *This photo album calls our vacation to mind.*

call something to someone's attention Go to **call someone's attention to something**.

call something up[†] to summon information from a computer. □ *John used his laptop to call the information up.* □ *With a few strokes on the computer keyboard, Sally called up the figures she was looking for.*

call the dogs off[†] 1. *Lit.* to order hunting or watch dogs to abandon their quarry. □ *They robber gave up and the guard called the dogs off.* □ *Call off the dogs!* **2.** *Fig.* to stop threatening, chasing, or hounding [a person]. □ *Tell the sheriff to call off the dogs. We caught the robber.* □ *Okay, you've caught me! Please call your dogs off!*

call the meeting to order Go to **call a meeting to order**.

call (the) roll and **take (the) roll** to call the names of people from a list of those enrolled, expecting them to reply if they are present. □ *After I call the roll, please open your books to page 12.* □ *I will take roll, and then we will do arithmetic.*

call the shots and **call the tune** *Fig.* to make the decisions; to decide what is to be done. □ *Sally always wants to call the shots, and Mary doesn't like to be bossed around. They don't get along well.* □ *Sally always wants to call the tune.*

call the tune Go to **previous**.

call to someone to shout to get someone's attention. □ *I called to Fred, but he didn't hear me.* □ *Did you hear me call to you?*

call (up)on someone 1. to visit someone. (*Upon* is formal and less commonly used than *on*.) □ *My mother's friends call upon her every Wednesday.* □ *Let's call on Mrs. Franklin this afternoon.* **2.** to choose someone to respond, as in a classroom. □ *The teacher called upon me, but I was not ready to recite.* □ *Please don't call on me. I can't remember a thing.*

call (up)on someone (for something) to choose someone to do or to help with some particular task. (*Upon* is formal and less commonly used than *on*.) □ *Can I call upon you for help?* □ *You can call on me at any time.*

call (up)on someone (to do something) to choose someone to do something. (*Upon* is formal and less commonly used than *on*.) □ *I call upon all of you to make your feelings*

known to your elected representatives. □ *I called on George for his help, but he refused.*

called to straw *Rur.* about to begin labor and childbirth. □ *Susan was called to straw when she was only seven months along.* □ *Nancy's nine months pregnant and could be called to straw any day now.*

the **calm before the storm** Go to the lull before the storm.

calm down to relax; to become less busy or active. □ *Now, now, calm down. You look so nervous.* □ *Please calm down. Nothing bad is going to happen.*

calm someone or an animal down[†] to cause someone or an animal to be less active, upset, or unsettled. □ *Please try to calm yourself down!* □ *Can you calm down your yapping dog?*

camp in the boondocks Go to in the boondocks.

camp in the boonies Go to in the boondocks.

camp it up [for performers] to overact or behave in an affected manner. □ *The cast began to camp it up in the second act, and the critics walked out. (Fixed order.)* □ *There is no need to camp it up. Play it the way it was written.*

camp out to live out of doors temporarily in a tent or camping vehicle, as on a vacation or special camping trip. □ *I love to camp out in the winter.*

campaign against someone or something **1.** to crusade or battle against someone or something. □ *Currently, I am campaigning against littering.* □ *Sarah is campaigning against crooked politicians.* **2.** to run one's political campaign against someone or something. □ *I campaigned against the incumbent and won.* □ *John spent a lot of time campaigning against Sarah for class president.*

campaign for someone or something to support actively someone or someone's candidacy for political office. □ *I would be very happy to campaign for you.* □ *I want to campaign for the winning candidate.*

Can do. I can definitely do it. (The opposite of **No can do.**) □ *Jane: Will you be able to get this finished by quitting time today? Alice: Can do. Leave it to me.* □ *Bob: Can you get this pack of papers over to the lawyer's office by noon? Bill: Can do. I'm leaving now. Bye.*

Can I help you? Go to Could I help you?

Can I leave a message? Go to Could I leave a message?

Can I see you again? Go to Could I see you again?

Can I see you in my office? Go to Could I see you in my office?

Can I speak to someone? Go to Could I speak to someone?

Can I take a message? Go to Could I take a message?

Can I take your order (now)? Go to Could I take your order (now)?

Can I tell her who's calling? Go to Could I tell him who's calling?

Can I use your powder room? Go to Could I use your powder room?

Can it! Shut up! □ *I've heard enough of your arguing. Can it!* □ *That's enough complaining from you! Can it!*

can (just) whistle for something *Fig.* can just forget about having something. □ *The last time Mary came over for dinner, she was downright rude. If she wants dinner at my house again, she can just whistle for it!* □ *I asked the boss for a promotion. He told me I could whistle for it.*

*a **can of worms** *Fig.* a very difficult issue or set of problems; an array of difficulties. (*Typically: **be ~;** **open ~.**) □ *This political scandal is a real can of worms.* □ *Let's not open that can of worms!*

can take it to the bank *Fig.* able to depend on the truthfulness of my statement: it is not counterfeit or bogus; to be able to **bank on** something. □ *Believe me. What I am telling you is the truth. You can take it to the bank.* □ *This information is as good as gold. You can take it to the bank.*

Can we continue this later? Go to Could we continue this later?

Can you excuse us, please? Go to Could you excuse us, please?

Can you hold? Go to Could you hold?

Can you imagine? Can you believe that?; Imagine that! □ *She wore jeans to the wedding. Can you imagine?* □ *Billy was eating the houseplant! Can you imagine?*

Can you keep a secret? Go to Could you keep a secret?

cancel each other out[†] [for the opposite effects of two things] to balance each other. □ *The cost of the meal you bought and what I owed you cancel each other out, so we're even.* □ *They canceled out each other.*

cancel out (of something) to withdraw from something. □ *I hate to cancel out of the event at the last minute, but this is an emergency.* □ *It's too late to cancel out.*

cancel someone out[†] Go to next.

cancel someone out of something and **cancel someone out**[†] **1.** to eliminate someone from something (as from a list of names). □ *We had to cancel them out.* □ *We canceled out all the people who did not show up.* **2.** *Sl.* to eliminate someone; to kill someone. □ *The drug lord threatened to cancel out his former partner for testifying against him.*

cancel someone's Christmas *Sl.* to kill someone; to destroy someone. (Underworld or jocular; the idea is that the dead person will not live until Christmas.) □ *If he keeps bugging me, I'm gonna cancel his Christmas.* □ *Willie threatened to cancel Richard's Christmas if Richard didn't pay up.*

cancel something out[†] to balance the effects of something. □ *Sending flowers might cancel the bad feelings out.* □ *The last payment canceled out the debt.*

*a **candidate for a pair of wings** *Euph.* someone who is likely to die; someone who is close to death. (Jocular. *Typically: **be ~;** **look like ~.**) □ *Whenever Jane wants to cross the street, she just walks out into traffic without looking. She's a candidate for a pair of wings, I say.* □ *Tom: How's Bill doing? I heard he was sick. Jane: Not good, I'm afraid. He looks like a candidate for a pair of wings.*

cannot See the expressions listed at **can't** and also those at **not able.**

cannot carry a tune Go to **can't carry a tune.**

cannot help doing something not able to refrain from doing something; not able not to do something. □ *Anne is such a good cook, I can't help eating everything she serves.* □ *Since John loves to shop, he can't help spending money.*

cannot see (any) further than the end of one's nose Go to see no further than the end of one's nose.

cannot see the forest for the trees Go to next.

cannot see the wood for the trees and **cannot see the forest for the trees** *Prov.* Cannot perceive the overview or important things because of concentrating too much on details. □ *The information presented in this textbook is so disorganized that I can't see the wood for the trees.* □ *The politician's opponents claimed that she couldn't see the forest for the trees, because she spent so much time trying to solve minor problems.*

cannot stomach someone or something Go to not able to stomach someone or something.

[can't] See the expressions listed at **not able**, as well as those listed below.

can't call one's soul one's own *Fig.* working for other people all the time. □ *Jane has to work two jobs and take care of both her aging parents. She can't call her soul her own.* □ *Between supporting his family and working off his brother's bad debts, Bob really can't call his soul his own.*

can't carry a tune and **cannot carry a tune; can't carry a tune in a bushel basket; can't carry a tune in a bucket; can't carry a tune in a paper sack** *Fig.* [to be] unable to sing a simple melody; lacking musical ability. □ *I wish that Tom wouldn't try to sing. He can't carry a tune.* □ *I don't know why Mary's in the choir. She can't carry a tune in a bushel basket.* □ *Joe likes to sing in the shower, though he can't carry a tune in a bucket.* □ *I'd try to hum the song for you, but I can't carry a tune in a paper sack.*

can't carry a tune in a bucket Go to previous.

can't carry a tune in a bushel basket Go to can't carry a tune.

can't carry a tune in a paper sack Go to can't carry a tune.

can't do anything with someone or something not [to be] able to manage or control someone or something. (Also with *cannot*.) □ *Bill is such a discipline problem. I can't do anything with him.* □ *My hair is such a mess. I just can't do anything with it.*

can't find one's butt with both hands (in broad daylight) *Sl.* is stupid or incompetent. (Use caution with *butt*, which is often considered crude.) □ *Why did they put Jim in charge? He can't find his butt with both hands!* □ *Tom: Jane seems like a bright girl. Bill: You've got to be kidding! She couldn't find her butt with both hands in broad daylight!*

can't hack it unable to do the job. □ *I thought delivering papers would be an easy job, but I just can't hack it.* □ *If you can't hack it, let me know, and I'll help you out.*

can't help but do something [to be] unable to choose any but one course of action. (Also with *cannot*.) □ *Her parents live nearby, so she can't help but go there on holidays.* □ *Bob is a tennis fan and can't help but travel to Wimbledon each year.*

can't hit the (broad) side of a barn *Rur.* cannot aim something accurately. □ *You're way off. You couldn't hit the broad side of a barn.* □ *Please don't try to throw the paper into the wastebasket. You can't hit the side of a barn.*

can't hold a candle to someone *Fig.* not [to be] equal to someone; unable to measure up to someone. (Also with *cannot*.) □ *Mary can't hold a candle to Ann when it comes to athletics.* □ *As for singing, John can't hold a candle to Jane.*

can't make heads or tails (out) of someone or something *Fig.* [to be] unable to understand someone or something. (Also with *cannot*.) □ *John is so strange. I can't make heads or tails of him.* □ *Do this report again. I can't make heads or tails out of it.*

Can't say (a)s I do, can't say (a)s I don't). *Rur.* I am not sure. □ *Tom: Do you know Mr. Smith? Mary: Well, I can't say as I do, can't say as I don't.* □ *Jane: What do you think of my cousin? Do you like him? Mary: Can't say's I do, can't say's I don't.*

can't say boo to a goose *Rur.* shy and not talkative. □ *I was surprised to see Joe so talkative at the party. Usually he can't say boo to a goose.* □ *She's a quiet little kid. Can't say boo to a goose.*

can't see a hole in a ladder stupid or drunk. □ *No use asking her questions. She can't see a hole in a ladder.* □ *After the big party, Joe needed someone to drive him home. He couldn't see a hole in a ladder.*

can't see beyond the end of one's nose Go to see no further than the end of one's nose.

can't see one's hand in front of one's face *Fig.* [to be] unable to see very far, usually due to darkness or fog. (Also with *cannot*.) □ *It was so dark that I couldn't see my hand in front of my face.* □ *Bob said that the fog was so thick he couldn't see his hand in front of his face.*

can't see straight *Fig.* cannot function (often because of strong emotion). □ *I am so mad I can't see straight.* □ *She left me so frustrated that I couldn't see straight.*

can't stand (the sight of) someone or something and **can't stomach** someone or something *Fig.* [to be] unable to tolerate someone or something; disliking someone or something extremely. (Also with *cannot*.) □ *I can't stand the sight of cooked carrots.* □ *Mr. Jones can't stomach the sight of blood.* □ *None of us can stand this place.* □ *Nobody can stand Tom when he smokes a cigar.*

can't stomach someone or something Go to previous.

can't wait (for something (to happen)) to be very eager, as if to be unable to endure the wait for something to happen. □ *I am so eager for my birthday to come. I just can't wait.*

can't wait (to do something) to be very eager, as if to be unable to endure the wait until it is possible to do something. □ *I'm glad it's almost summertime—I just can't wait to go swimming!*

cap and gown the academic cap or mortarboard and the robe worn in formal academic ceremonies. □ *We all had to rent cap and gown for graduation.* □ *I appeared wearing my cap and gown, but I had shorts on underneath because it gets so hot at that time of year.*

capable of doing something having the ability to do something. ☐ *Do you think Tom is capable of lifting 200 pounds?*
☐ *No one I know is capable of such a crime!*

capitalize on something Fig. to build on something; to exploit something, such as an opportunity of talent, to one's own benefit. ☐ *Let's try to capitalize on the strength of the economy and invest for the future.* ☐ *Capitalize on your experience in the field and you'll do well in the interview.*

capitulate to someone or something to surrender or submit to someone or something. ☐ *The general finally capitulated to the enemy.* ☐ *I won't capitulate in this argument.*

captain of industry Fig. a high-ranking corporation officer; a wealthy and successful capitalist. ☐ *The captains of industry manage to hang on to their money no matter what.* ☐ *It's fun to see those captains of industry drive up in their limousines.*

capture someone's imagination Fig. to intrigue someone; to interest someone in a lasting way; to stimulate someone's imagination. ☐ *The story of the young wizard has captured the imagination of the world's children.*

*a **card** Fig. an entertaining and clever person who says or does funny things. (*Typically: **act like ~**; **be ~**.) ☐ *He is such a card. Always making jokes.* ☐ *Mary is a card, and she has to learn to take things seriously sometimes.*

card-carrying member Fig. an official member of some group, originally, the communist party. ☐ *Bill is a card-carrying member of the electricians union.*

the **cards are stacked against one** [informal] luck is against one. (See also **stack the deck (against someone or something)**.) ☐ *I have the worst luck. The cards are stacked against me all the time.* ☐ *How can I accomplish anything when the cards are stacked against me?*

care about someone or something 1. to hold someone or something dear; to prize someone or something. ☐ *I really care about you.* ☐ *I care very much about my family.* 2. to have even minimal regard for someone or something. (Does not imply any of the tender feelings expressed in ①.) ☐ *Don't you care about animals?* ☐ *I care about what happens in Washington.*

care for someone to feel tenderly toward someone; to love someone. ☐ *I care for you a great deal, Walter.* ☐ *I care for you too, Alice.*

care for someone or something to take care of someone or something. ☐ *Will you care for my cat while I am away?* ☐ *I would be happy to care for your child.*

care for something to like the taste of some kind of food or drink. (Usually used with a negative.) ☐ *I don't care for sweet potatoes.* ☐ *I don't care for sweet desserts.*

care nothing about someone or something to have no regard or respect for someone or something. ☐ *You have hurt me with your insults. I care nothing about you!* ☐ *She cares nothing about your money!*

care nothing for someone or something not to like someone or something. ☐ *She cares nothing for your suggestion.* ☐ *Sarah cares nothing for Jeff.*

care to do something to want to do something; to be willing to do something. ☐ *I really don't care to see that movie.* ☐ *Would you care to go out for dinner?*

careful not to do something using care to avoid some difficulty or difficulties. ☐ *Please be careful not to discuss politics with Mr. Brown.* ☐ *Please be careful not to leave the house unlocked.*

careful (with something) treating or handling something with caution. ☐ *Please be careful with the vase. It's old and valuable.* ☐ *That's too big a load. Be careful!*

carp about someone or something to complain about someone or something. ☐ *You are always carping about all your petty problems at work.* ☐ *Stop carping about Randy!*

carp at someone (about someone or something) to complain to someone about someone or something. ☐ *Why are you always carping at me about your family?* ☐ *You are always carping at Joan about her brother.*

carp at someone or something to criticize someone or something. ☐ *Poor Clara is carping at Bill's carelessness again.* ☐ *Please stop carping at me.*

carry (a lot of) weight (with someone or something) Fig. to be very influential with someone or some group of people. ☐ *Your argument does not carry a lot of weight with me.* ☐ *The senator's testimony carried a lot of weight with the council.*

carry a secret to the grave and **carry a secret to one's grave** Fig. to never reveal a secret, even to the day of one's death. ☐ *John carried our secret to his grave.* ☐ *Trust me, I will carry your secret to the grave!*

carry a torch (for someone) and **carry the torch (for someone)** Fig. to be in love with someone who is not in love with you; to brood over a hopeless love affair. ☐ *John is carrying a torch for Jane.* ☐ *Is John still carrying a torch after all this time?*

carry coals to Newcastle Prov. to do something unnecessary; to do something that is redundant or duplicative. (Newcastle is an English town from which coal was shipped to other parts of England.) ☐ *Mr. Smith is so rich he doesn't need any more money. To give him a gift certificate is like carrying coals to Newcastle.*

carry on to behave badly or mischievously. ☐ *The children always carry on when the teacher's out of the room.* ☐ *Stop carrying on and go to sleep!*

carry on (about someone or something) to make a great fuss over someone or something; to cry (especially for a long time or uncontrollably) about someone or something. (Note the variation in the examples.) ☐ *Billy, stop carrying on about your tummy ache like that.* ☐ *The child carried on endlessly when his mother scolded him.* ☐ *When the soldier finally came home, his wife cried and carried on for hours.* ☐ *Calm down. There's no need to carry on so.*

carry on somehow to manage to continue or endure, in spite of problems. ☐ *Even though we did not have a lot of money, we managed to carry on somehow.* ☐ *Don't worry about us. We will carry on somehow.*

carry on (to something) to continue on to some place or some time. ☐ *Please keep reading. Carry on to the next page.* ☐ *Please carry on with your report.*

carry on (with someone) to flirt with someone; to have a love affair with someone. ☐ *It looks like Linda is carrying on with James.*